OFF THE RECORD

THE GHOST OF ELVIS PRESLEY

The Kings of Clark County · Book 2

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Chapter One

Cal Chance walked into the cavernous office of Cooper Investigations at 9:15 a.m., a full quarter of an hour after the meeting had started.

He carried a half-full coffee from the stand opposite the office doors.

Americano. Triple shot. Black.

He shaded his eyes against fluorescent lights brighter than anything the Strip had to offer and weaved between the desks, looking for a face he recognized. By the third row, he gave up. The room was full of strangers talking calmly into phones and tapping busily at keyboards.

Cal avoided the office during daylight hours, and by extension the people who kept them. One look around confirmed the policy. All he saw were the same cheap suits and the same blank expressions.

The coffee wasn't just a necessity; it was a statement. It said, *I know I'm late, but I still had time to stop for coffee.* Cal knew it was pointless and counterproductive, but he didn't care. Mallory, his supervisor, had called a daytime meeting at short notice. She knew what she was getting.

Cal assumed it was about Todd Bailey's complaint. Anything else would have been an email or a phone call. Nobody ever got called into the office to be told "well done."

He'd closed the Cactus Man case weeks ago. Technically solved it, anyway. Todd Bailey's wife had hired Cooper Investigations to find out who was stealing her mail. Cal had planted a camera in a cheap Walmart cactus and caught something far more profitable than stolen letters: Todd sneaking home at midday with a woman who definitely wasn't

Mrs. Bailey.

Cal had made a side deal with Todd—cash for silence—and that would have been the end of it if Todd had shown even the smallest hint of remorse. Instead, he'd kept playing the victim, so Cal had handed the footage to Mrs. Bailey anyway.

Win-win. At least for him.

Except now Todd was threatening to sue the firm, and Mallory was furious. She was already looking for a reason to fire him, and a furious Mallory meant Cal's thin employment prospects were about to get thinner.

The meeting rooms were at the back of the open-plan office. Cal took the long way, via the desk of Roger Wilkins: his occasional partner in the pursuit of crime and full-time office gremlin. If anyone knew why Cal had been summoned, it would be Roger.

The desk wasn't occupied. Lived-in, but not occupied.

Coke Zero cans fought for real estate with snack wrappers and paperwork. Under the desk sat a gym bag that had seen better days, if not the inside of a gym.

Whatever problems Roger was having at home were evidently still in play, and the office was cheaper than even the most run-down motel in Vegas.

Cal maneuvered around the remaining desks to the door that led to the meeting rooms. He was sure he'd been issued a keycard to the inner sanctum at some point, but he had no idea where it was.

He slowed as he approached, hoping someone would come through so he could tailgate them, but there was little foot traffic and even less interest in helping him.

With no other option, he knocked.

Chapter Two

Roger came out of one of the offices and pressed the button to let him through.

"Afternoon, Cal."

Cal nodded. Everyone was a comedian.

Roger wore an expression Cal didn't like, a combination of *you're in trouble* and *I know why*. It sat on the Gremlin's face like a badge of dishonor.

Cal was about to ask what was going on, but Roger had already turned, slowly, and was heading back to the conference room. Cal rarely saw the Gremlin away from his desk, and there was definitely a spring in his step.

Cal took a beat, and a gulp of his cooling coffee.

He was in no rush.

Once Roger had disappeared through the conference room door, Cal followed. He walked in with his coffee cup pressed to his lips. Deliberately.

He'd expected Mallory to be there; she was the one who'd called him late yesterday afternoon and told him to attend. Beyond that, it was a toss-up between Human Resources and Todd Bailey, depending on whether this was mediation or something more permanent. Cal wasn't sure which would be worse.

But it was just the three of them.

Mallory sat at the head of the conference table, a manila folder squared precisely in front of her. Roger took the seat to her right, still wearing that irritating expression.

Mallory O'Shea had been inserted as Cal's supervisor six months earlier, and they had clashed from the first meeting. Mallory was about paperwork and accountability. She was an

office manager promoted beyond her skill set, and Cal doubted she'd ever done a day of fieldwork.

Ask Mallory her opinion of Cal and she'd tell you he was conceited, obnoxious, and more concerned with results than reputation.

Cal would concede she was absolutely right.

Mallory didn't waste time on pleasantries or small talk. It was one of the few traits Cal could get behind.

"We've had an email."

Cal sat motionless. It was information he couldn't use, and couldn't respond to without incriminating himself. He wasn't about to justify his actions in the Cactus Man case until he was absolutely sure that was why they were here.

Mallory looked at him a second too long.

"Have you read it, Cal?"

It was posed as a question, but everyone in the room already knew the answer.

"I'm not sure I recall the contents," was as close as Cal would get to admitting he didn't read his emails.

Mallory shook her head but said nothing. It was all part of the game they played, and they had both learned not to waste energy on the little things.

"Let me remind you."

She punched a few keys on her laptop and picked up a pair of glasses from the table. Cal had a thing for women in glasses. He looked away. Not the time, and not the place.

Without looking up, Mallory read it aloud.

Dear Ms. O'Shea,

I am writing to remind you that your firm now has fourteen days in which to find our missing Elvis Presley.

I was under the impression, following our meeting at the Skyline Overlook, that Mr. Chase would keep us informed of his progress. To date, we have received no updates.

Mallory stopped reading and put her glasses back on the table.

Mr. Chase. They'd gotten his name wrong, but that was the least of his problems.

So this had nothing to do with the Cactus Man case. This was about the missing Elvis.

A few days ago, Mallory had tracked him down at the office after hours and dropped a case on his desk.

Find Elvis Presley.

Not an impersonator. A man legally named Elvis Presley and, more importantly, legally registered to officiate weddings in Nevada.

Influencer Sienna Vale had hired him to perform her social media marriage to Henry Hartwell at the Skyline Overlook. Multiple sponsors, endorsement deals, and a luxury vodka tie-in all hinged on the name "Elvis Presley" appearing on the marriage certificate. Cal still had no idea why, but the couple's representative, Sophia, had been very insistent.

Wedding Elvis had vanished without a trace six months before, and Cooper Investigations had been hired to find him. For some reason, they thought Cal was the man to do it.

So far, the investigation had turned up ten people legally named Elvis Presley scattered across Clark County. As far as Cal was concerned, that was nine too many.

The first Elvis he'd found ran a shoe repair shop near the Strip: a sixty-something Welshman who'd never worn a sequined jumpsuit in his life. Cal had only stopped by to cross him off the list, but he'd walked into the middle of a different crime. A pair of blue suede shoes that had once belonged to the *original* Elvis Presley, the King himself, had been stolen.

The shoes had gone from the Welsh Elvis's shop to the Vale-Hartwell wedding venue as props, courtesy of Sienna's overzealous assistant. Cal had stolen them back—technically, returned stolen property—and nearly gotten himself fired in the process. Somehow, that had convinced Sienna he was exactly the man to find her missing Elvis.

He'd also met Lisa Marie Presley, the cobbler's daughter, who wore her hair in a 1950s pompadour and looked at Cal like he was both trouble and worth the risk.

Now Cal had two weeks to find Wedding Elvis. And all signs pointed to Death Valley, where, he'd been told, another Elvis Presley had sold his collection and disappeared into the desert six months earlier.

Cal didn't believe in coincidences.

He also still had no idea why this required a meeting.

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TO BE CONTINUED

Thanks for reading

The Ghost of Elvis Presley is out in January 2027. You're on the list, so you'll hear first.

CAN'T WAIT? CAL'S AVAILABLE NOW

FACE VALUE

A casino says Todd Bailey owes them $100,000. Cal Chance is the only person he doesn't trust enough to help.

GET IT ON AMAZON

THE MAN WITH THE BLUE SUEDE SHOES

Elvis Presley has left the building. Now Cal Chance has sixteen days to find him.

GET IT ON AMAZON

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